learned that one can detach one's self completely in such cases and merely make little moaning sounds at odd intervals to indicate one's attention is riveted, and the speaker is thoroughly satisfied.

I had ordered Shrimp Diabolo and was squaring away, quite prepared to eat with gusto, when the agent's wife, eyeing my dish with interest, said, "Well, what have you there, my, that looks good, I've always been interested in shrimp, been eating them ever since I was so high, but I don't seem to recognize this way of cooking them, it smells good, what do they call it, where's the menu, I wonder why I didn't notice it on the menu when I was ordering, does it taste good, let me see what it tastes like . . ."

And at this point, she speared one of my shrimps and carried it off.

I stared at her with horror. I hate having anyone sample my plate. I don't sample yours, you don't sample mine is my way of looking at meals.

There are some principles that even the thought of fifty thousand a year won't affect. Once she had speared my shrimp there was no longer a chance in Hades that Bob's agent could have me as a client. My heart hardened, my mind closed, and I settled back to my mere ten thousand a year.

And I never again got even that close to considering a literary agent.

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On my rounds earlier that day, Mac Talley had told me that NAL had paid Marty Greenberg a $500 advance for the paperback rights to I, Robot. It seemed to me that Marty had never mentioned this in any of his discussions of my earnings.

I called him up on the twenty-sixth therefore and said, "Hey Marty, what about the $500 you got from Mac Talley?"

It may have come as a surprise to Marty to find out that I knew

about this. At any rate he started yelling at me and calling me a variety of bad names.

I survived the barrage and insisted that he pay me—and he did in small, slow installments.

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